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Giacomo Gates — Part II

Giacomo Gates is a jazz singer in the truest sense of the word. His bop-inflected vocal style upholds the tradition pioneered by King Pleasure, Eddie Jefferson and Jon Hendricks. His latest recording, with original lyrics, is called "What Time is It?"

Part two was conducted in Utica, NY on November 11, 2017, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Good morning, Giacomo.

GG: Good morning.

MR: We've got to stop meeting like this. This is part two. I think part one was actually earlier in the morning than this.

GG: Yeah, probably was, but I'm happy to be here for the second time and I had a ball the first time.

MR: So for those people on YouTube, my name is Monk Rowe and this is Giacomo Gates, and we just saw you perform last night. I took copious notes, so I hope you'll analyze your own performance with great elan. It occurred to me maybe during the second or third song when you were doing vocalese, how magnificent those solos were that you and the vocalese masters set words to, that one of the ways to appreciate those solos is to listen to them with vocalese, because they are just musical gems.

GG: I agree. I agree. The people that started to do that — Eddie Jefferson, Jon Hendricks, Annie Ross — they had great solos to choose from. People played lyrical stories, melodic lyrical stories. I'm not saying it's easy to put lyrics to that, but the solos are just amazing. Amazing.

MR: Can you explain why?

GG: Yeah. A very long time ago I got to sit in with Lou Donaldson because the bass player that I knew was playing with Lou. And he said, "Hey man, let this cat sit in." This was a long time ago. And Lou at first didn't know me, why would he have me sit in? And the bass player kept making it — and I'm like, "Please leave Lou alone." And he finally did bring me up. And I know that Lou plays a lot of Charlie Parker. So I said, "Can we do 'Lady Be Good'?" And I sang "Lady Be Good," and then Lou played a solo, and then I started to sing the Charlie Parker solo, with lyrics by Eddie Jefferson. And Lou played it along with me, in my key. Yeah. Right like that. So I while I'm singing I'm going wow. So I finished the tune and I thanked him for letting me sit in, and I go off. And later on, on the break, "Mr. Donaldson, thank you for letting me sit in." I said, "Obviously you are familiar with that Charlie Parker I mean you nailed it in my key." And Lou said to me,

"Well, for me that's one of Charlie Parker's most well-constructed solos. And then here's the punch line. He said, "But he had to play something, because he was standing next to Lester Young." So that put the whole thing into context for me. Not only was it a great solo, but I didn't know that when he played that solo it was at Jazz at the Philharmonic and Prez was on the gig. And Charlie Parker was very young at the time, or relatively young, and he knew that he was going to be playing with his idol, Lester Young. So he worked it out. Because "Lady Be Good" was one of Prez's things that he soloed on. So yeah, I mean if you've got somebody like Charlie Parker to think what he's going to play and then fortunately it gets recorded, and then you get a guy like Eddie Jefferson saying, "I think I could put words to that." It can't be bad.

MR: It can't be bad.

GG: So all I'm trying to do is do it again. Yeah. That really put a big light on it for me. When he told me that. Because those solos, those guys played another song. It wasn't just blowing over changes. They played another song.

MR: I wish that that could be taught. I'm not sure that it can.

GG: I don't know if it can either but I think that people who solo need to know that. They need to know that this isn't blowing over changes. This is a spontaneous composition. It's another song. And you have to have the facility — I mean I couldn't do it on a horn. If I put a horn in my mouth I wouldn't be able to get a noise out of it never mind a — but you have to have the facility to be able to play what you think, or how it makes you feel. And those guys embellished the melody. You can always hear a slice of the song. You hear the song in there. I don't think that's the easiest thing to do. You have to be conscious of doing it. But you have to know the song.

MR: The gig last night, you inflect a lot of humor in it. One of your best lines was, you told a joke and hardly anybody laughed, and you said, "This is the funny stuff folks."

GG: Yeah, well.

MR: And that got the laugh.

GG: That got the laugh, yeah. Well I think, I don't know again, you know I'm just winging it. People come to a musical presentation. I don't know if they realize that as far as I'm concerned they're allowed to laugh and have a good time. It's not okay, we have to listen to this now. No. Have a good time. It's supposed to be fun. I can remember going to listen to I think it was Joe Lovano and Bob Dorough together at Birdland, maybe fifteen years ago, maybe more. And they were funny. And I was laughing. And nobody else was. And people were looking at me like, "How rude. What's he laughing about?" Because what they're playing is funny. What they're doing and saying. Not like slap your leg funny, but funny because their intention is to make you have a good time. It's humorous. I don't know if I laugh out loud but I certainly smile when I listen to Thelonious Monk.

Because his music's got a sense of humor in it. So sometimes you have to let them know, it's okay to laugh, folks. You can have a good time while you're here.

MR: Yeah and the whole atmosphere of these kinds of gigs is it needs to be very relaxed for you because you are working with guys that you've never met before on some occasions, so you turn around and you say, "Excuse me, we're going to rehearse." That becomes part of that kind of gig.

GG: And I try to let the audience know if we have a bump it's because this is fresh. There's no rehearsal here. We might have talked through a couple of tunes. Or, "When you get to the bridge this is going to happen okay?" But it's not rehearsed. We didn't spend three hours doing this prior to the gig.

MR: I think it's informative for people. Because a lot of times people who are not that familiar with jazz, they, one of the phrases you hear is, "Well how do they do that? How do they know to do what they're doing?" And to actually witness a little talk-through is informative for the audience.

GG: Yeah. I think they should know what happens. Listen this is — but, "They're just jamming." No they're not. Jam is something that goes on peanut butter. This ain't no jam session. They all know the route or the map, they all know the form, and we follow it together. So if you hear the band play something for seven minutes —

[gap]

MR: We're back. Okay. Okay so I'll just pick up.

What inspired you to move from the construction business into the music world?

GG: Well when I went up there I was going to stay for a year and a year started to go by and I liked living up there. I left one year and went to work in Washington State in construction. I got to sit in a little bit in a couple of places in Olympia and Seattle. I went back to Alaska. I went to Arizona for a season and worked on a road job. Went back to Alaska. Came back to the East Coast for about eight or nine months, went back to Alaska. There was something about it. I mean there's two things that'll happen to you if you moved then anyway, because it's very different now up there. Either you love it and you can't leave or you want to get out of there as soon as possible. But after being up there for almost twelve years, someone said to me, "You know there's a summer arts festival up here." I'd been living, going on for probably eight or nine years. I didn't know about it because in the summer I was somewhere remote working, which is that's what I wanted. I didn't want to be in town. I liked Fairbanks but I liked the out more. I wanted to be out there, I wanted to be in the Brooks Range. I wanted to be on the Arctic Slope. I wanted to be on the Kenai Peninsula. I wanted to be on the Aleutians. I wanted to see what it was all about. And there was this summer arts festival. And I happened to be just coming off of a job. So I'm going to be in town for a month. And I looked at it, and the

performing headliners, one was Sarah Vaughan and one was Steve Allen. Yeah. I said wow. And it was a two week festival. And it wasn't just performances. It was workshops that you could attend. And these workshops were from square dancing to photography to charcoal drawing to classical violin, singing, dancing, you name it. Arts festival. And they had to two week cabaret class. Not my thing but the instructor was a woman by the name of Chris Calloway. Cab's daughter. Well that was enough for me to sign up. Cab Calloway's daughter is teaching a cabaret class? Wow. And it was going to be a piano player and a bass player and you'd have to audition, and if you got in you'd take these classes. Two hours a day for two weeks. And then a performance at the end of it. So I signed up. You know I'm in Fairbanks during the summer to have a good time. And after about the third or fourth class, I'm sitting in the back and there's a gentleman sitting back there with a clip board, and he's writing, and I thought he was a participant in the class. So we struck up a conversation and it turned out that he was a writer from San Francisco who was up there writing about this festival. And his name was Grover Sales. Come to find out, he's an educator, an author, he wrote *Jazz: America's Classical Music*, he wrote a Charlie Parker biography, he had the most extensive interviews with Thelonious Monk, he taught at one of the big colleges in San Francisco, I can't remember the name off hand but he was this very interesting, very hip guy. He was Dizzy Gillespie's road manager in the late 1950s, so when I found out that I mean I was just pumping him and he was happy to tell me all these stories. And he heard me sing a couple of times and he said to me, "Where are you from?" I said, "I live here in Fairbanks." He said, "That's not what I asked you, where are you from?" I said, "Connecticut." He said, "Yeah." He said, "You know what you do is very different than what is going on here." I said, "Yeah, I know but I'm coming to learn something and I never really got to do this in the way that they're explaining it so I'm just having a good time." And they had like sixty instructors from all over the world. Some were classical. Fred Budda, a famous drummer who has now passed, from Boston. There were a couple of Boston guys, there were some San Francisco guys, New York guys, and my take on the music was a little different than the rest of the cabaret singers, and they encouraged me. They said, "You know you've got your own sound." One of them said to me, "What are you doing up here, man, you'll never get heard up here." I said, "I'm not trying to get heard, I live up here. I work up here." And they couldn't understand like why. Why would you want to live up here? Well because it's beautiful. It gets a little cool in the winter, and a little dark, but I didn't come up here for the weather, I came up here for an adventure and it just kind of kept going. And I was trying to make money. You know I was just a po' boy from Bridgeport. So I was trying to make what they used to call a grub stake. You know? And after a while I got encouraged from these people. The music felt so good. I was on a bandstand with

people who really could play, as opposed to people who couldn't play that good. That's who I was usually playing with. And it felt good. And I thought you know I'm getting kind of tired of bouncing around on a piece of equipment, maybe I'll go back to the East Coast. I'll go to New York City and I'll see if I can make a little noise. Because these people encouraged me. And in my mind, and I've said this to a few people and I'm going to say it again although I don't have rehearsed lines, but I knew that — I went back to Connecticut in '89. I knew that Thelonious Monk and Charlie Parker had already passed but I thought I might run into them in New York. Well when I got there they were going baby, but I did get to meet some people who I was knocked out to meet like Max Roach and Lou Donaldson and Mose Allison and I got to work with Walter Bishop Junior and Lou and I met guys that were my age but they were heavy hitters: Jon Faddis, Richie Cole, and I got to interact with them and talk to them and sit in with them and they encouraged me. And Buddy Tate I mentioned. Bill Finnegan, Eddie Bert, people that you interviewed that I watched the interviews and listened. I just felt like wow, I was inspired by them and by being able to partake in what they were doing. But it wasn't easy.

MR: Did you have your grub stake to see you through for a while?

GG: I was still trying to — I was working part time. I was driving a limousine, I was driving a school bus, whew. That was a tough date, driving a school bus. No I drove just about everything with wheels. But the freight on a school bus is difficult to deal with. Livestock is easier. I don't know, electrical appliances are easier.

MR: What grade level were you driving?

GG: Oh, they called it junior high. Seventh and eighth grade. I mean when I went to school it was seventh and eighth grade it wasn't junior high, you went to grammar school and then you went to high school. But junior high, these kids are like, they don't even know if they're standing up or sitting down or laying down, their hormones are all over the place. They're just nuts. And you know, I want quiet when I drive. Yeah that's going to happen. So I mean I would do a gig on the weekend and be like lifted. And then Monday morning, 6:30 a.m. there's kids on the bus screaming and I'm going, "I just did this and now I'm doing this." So it brings back some reality. It makes you realize that this is the planet earth, you've got to deal with some other stuff. I didn't get plucked and they put me on Carnegie Hall. And that's a good thing.

MR: Well I was going to ask you about sort of that if you had gone the route of Berklee School of Music, get out, meet somebody and start working, in other words, I'm sort of describing what happens today hopefully for people.

GG: Yeah.

MR: But I wonder if your attitude about the music would have been different.

GG: I wouldn't have known half of the stuff that I found out the best way, from experience. The experience is the best teacher. The tuition is very high. Yeah. But it's worth it 'cause if they pluck you out of a music school, you might know how to play or execute, and then they make you leader. Well you don't even know how to be a sideman. How can you be a leader if you've never been a sideman? And if you've never worked for a good leader and a bad leader, how do you know what it is to be a good leader? If you've never been taken care of by a good leader how do you know how to take care of your guys. To get them paid, to get them fed, to get them accommodated, or whatever. Yeah, "You take care of this, I'm busy." No, no, no, no. That's your responsibility if you're the leader, in my mind. But I look at it, I mean I'm all wrong man. I'm looking at it the way it used to be. I thought that you learn your craft and then you work on it, and you learn it while you're working on it, and you amass a repertoire and you learn about protocol and you learn how to work in what Lenny Bruce used to call "toilets." Dumps. Dives. Where nobody's listening. And maybe you can learn how to get them listening and have respect for the musicians that you are with on the bandstand, and have respect for the bandstand. I mean I'd never walk up on somebody's bandstand and say, "Hey man, do you guys—" "What are you doing up here?" That's the way it used to be. Now everything's, "Oh sure baby, come on up." You know? So I'm knocked out that I was able to find out from some of the people that I looked up to how to do it. Because I think that there is a certain protocol or je ne sais quoi or whatever you want to call it. The way to do it, there's a way to do it. One could easily do something wrong with those guys. Like Billy Mitchell. I got to sit in at a gig, and I don't know if we talked about this. Yeah I mean Billy Mitchell, "Yeah come by and sit in." Billy Mitchell is running the band. Billy Mitchell from the Basie band? Yeah. Well you didn't just, "Yeah baby everything's fine, just come on up. Whatever you got is good." No. "What do you got?" Before you get up here I want to know what you're all about. I mean not in that way, but that's the essence. What did Miles say? I could tell the way a cat walks if he can swing or not. They make judgement calls on you before you even open your mouth. And I think that was probably all right. Because they had been the route. And they know. Now, sure it's fine, come on up. "How'd you sound?" "It sounded great man." "Really?" "Yeah." You know, like everybody drives a car. But not everybody is a good driver.

MR: Well how the heck does a student these days learn that protocol? You had sort of mentioned that in today's jazz education it seems that there are some people are now teaching who weren't able to participate in that learning process. So you have mostly book-schooled professors now teaching another generation.

GG: Yeah. Well it's hard to teach somebody something that you don't know about. I mean they don't know about it. They don't know about maybe getting kicked off the bandstand.

You know? “Nice try baby, come back another time.” So that’ll either make you quit or go home and work on it. Or you know I went to watch before I ever tried to do this, I was a fan. So I saw Joe Williams sing a lot of times. And I wasn’t just listening to him sing, I would watch the way he would get up from the stool. I mean you do something a little different when you’re on stage, because they realized that yeah you’re listening to me but you’re also looking at me. So you have to present yourself in a certain way. Miles Davis, I want to get back to what we’re talking about but Miles Davis, you know, Miles Davis didn’t do an act, but people came to see what he was going to do next. I wonder what Miles is going to wear? I wonder if he’s going to walk off again. Gee I hope he turns his back on me. You know. I mean what he did made people come to listen and look at him. Because it was interesting. What’s he going to do now? Is he going to talk? I remember watching something where he holds up the band’s members names on a placard. Somebody would solo and he would hold up his placard. Hold it up, put it down. Wow that’s different.

MR: Miles did that?

GG: Miles did that, yeah.

MR: I had not heard that.

GG: With Kenny Garrett. When Kenny Garrett was playing with him and the cat now, he’s really a great player, a piano player, his name escapes me.

MR. Kirkland? Kenny Kirkland?

GG: No. He plays with the famous trio. They’ve been together forever. They play nothing but standards, they never rehearsed. They played great.

MR: Oh you mean Keith Jarrett.

GG: Keith Jarrett, yeah. He’d hold up a sign, “Keith Jarrett.” And the audience is going wow. That’s show biz. So I went to see people, and now, I’m not saying that any student should come to see me. That’s not what I’m saying. But I have done gigs in clubs where the last set is a jam session. Not for me. When I’m done then they bring a different rhythm section up and it’s a jam session. In come all the students. Why weren’t you here to catch whatever was happening first? Maybe you could learn something from it. “I’m not interested in that man, I know what I’m doing.” You do? Where’d you learn it? “I go to school.” Oh. How come for everything else that you do there’s an apprenticeship. You can’t just — you don’t go buy a hammer and a saw and you’re a carpenter. You’ve got to be a helper for three years so you learn how to do it.

MR: Good point.

GG: Plumbers have to learn more than water runs downhill. There’s more to learn than that. You’ve got to be an apprenticeship. You’ve got to carry the tools for everybody first. That doesn’t happen anymore.

MR: Good words. I was wondering last night, I observed something that these lengthy vocalese things you were doing, you had it all memorized.

GG: I was lip syncing man.

MR: You were lip syncing. That answers that question.

GG: I had a cassette player underneath the bandstand.

MR: But then I thought it was interesting because when you went to do your poem about time, which I think is very clever, that you had to read your own work.

GG: Yeah.

MR: But you had memorized all the vocalese from Eddie Jefferson and Jon Hendricks.

GG: And even I mean I read lyrics to songs, they're in my head. But to read the poem? I don't know, I never sat down to try to memorize it. It's just, and I kind of like the — you know I think about that. It looks different when I pick up a piece of paper and read a poem. I was reading a poem.

MR: Yeah.

GG: It's a presentation. You know?

MR: It is. Okay. Well I have a game show scenario for you.

GG: Seventeen.

MR: How did you know?

GG: I just kind of took a wild guess.

MR: This is "Giacomo Gates plays Finish That Lyric."

GG: Okay.

MR: Okay, so I'm going to vocalize something to you, and we'll start with something easy. Gimme that wine —

GG: Gimme that wine. Yeah. What?

MR: Okay what comes next?

GG: Unhand that bottle.

MR: Gimme that wine. Unhand that bottle.

GG: I can't get loose. Though I can't cut loose without my juice.

MR: That's right. What is that, gotta have hot Lucy.

GG: Yeah. When I go walkin'.

MR: When I go walkin'. That's right. Okay. Here's an old ballad. The very thought of you makes my heart sing.

GG: Oh yeah. I know it but I can't tell you.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Now this is one I think you'll know. There I go, there I go, there I go.

GG: There I go again. Pretty baby, you are the soul that stops my control. Yeah.

MR: James Moody said a funny thing about that song, that the reason he played the intro the way he did is cause he was playing it on alto when he normally played it on tenor or something.

GG: Was it a borrowed horn or something?

MR: A borrowed horn or something, and he was feeling his way through it. I love that stuff. Okay how about this one? One two three four five six seven.

GG: Steps to heaven.

MR: Yeah, but it's also your own thing.

GG: Oh that one. One two three four five six seven. How many things do you need? Eight nine and ten or eleven, or is it just greed?

MR: Money and cars.

GG: Big apartments. What does it take to have fun? Too many things make my head spin. Better to have one.

MR: So how does that song start for you when you work on your own tunes? Is there a—

GG: Well Monk, the title. The title and the melody. So Monk called a tune "Think of One."

MR: Oh, right.

GG: So you can't write lyrics to a song, a pre-established instrumental, without changing the title. Think of one. Too many things. So I was driving a limousine at the time, part time. And I would pick up this guy every Monday morning at 5 a.m. in Greenwich, Connecticut. Greenwich, Connecticut is the Hollywood Hills of Connecticut. Beautiful big English Tudor, a Bentley parked in the driveway, maybe a German sports car. This is early 90s. Swimming pool, tennis courts, gated driveway. I'd pick this guy up, nice guy. Get in the car he'd sleep. I'd take him to the London airport — er, I'd take him to JFK but I'd take him to London Air. He'd get on the plane, go there. I would pick him up Thursday night at midnight and bring him back to Greenwich and drop him off. And he'd sleep in the car. I did that for, I don't know, two months. I mean I was driving for a car service, a limousine service, and this was part, one of the jobs that I did. Nice guy, didn't talk much because he was tired. He was shot. Air travel back and forth to London every week. Of course I only picked him up and brought him back and forth. One time I picked up his wife, she was flying somewhere. And another time I picked up their Au Pair. She was going back to Scandinavia, to Sweden. And I never — of course I wasn't around for this but I never saw him driving the Bentley or the Porsche. I never saw him playing tennis. I never saw him in the swimming pool. One two three four five six seven. How many things do you need? Eight nine ten or eleven. Is it just greed? That's where those lyrics came from. Because he's working so hard to have all of this he never got to use any of it. Maybe his wife did occasionally. Who knows? I don't know. I'm going to say something that's way out of whack that's supposed to be funny: maybe she was busy

with the pool boy. I don't know. But he couldn't take care of anything because he was busy making money. Well how much money do you need? How much do you need? How about honing in on one thing. At least in that moment in time that's the way I felt. Now I wish I had the English Tudor and the Bentley. No not really.

MR: I bet you'd make use of it.

GG: Yeah, man.

MR: I like the fact that in your vocabulary you still have the words "it's a gas" "solid" that kind of stuff.

GG: Well I'm a fan of Lester Young and his lingo, and Lenny Bruce, and Lord Buckley, and all those hipsters. They were, to me, they were funny and bright and articulate and they said a lot with a little. You know?

MR: When you were scatting last night on "Four" I took note of the one note that you held for like four bars. I think it was the last four bars of the form. You found that note, which fit every chord, and the fact that you heard that I thought was informative.

GG: Well thank you. That comes from familiarity of the changes. If you do it over and over and over again you know what fits before you try to make it fit. You know. You know what I'm talking about. It kind of happens. If I work with students about how to do this, how do you do this, well you can call it rehearsal and you can call it practicing, but I call it tedious repetition. You do it and do it and do it and do it. It's work. And then all of a sudden it's not work, it's wait a minute, I think I got it. And now it evolves into something else. Now it's fun. So other things come to you. They just come to you if your mind is open. So you know all these changes but you know the one that's going to work. It just does.

MR: And you also knew that it was a good way — because it came right at the end of your choruses. And it's like a good way to pass it on. That's what I thought.

GG: But you know the language though.

MR: It sets up the next guy.

GG: You know the language. So you hear what I'm saying, and you get it. Hopefully some people who might not know the language get it. Because I'm doing it, I mean I'm in the moment. I really am in the moment when I'm doing whatever it is that I do. And I hope they get it. But I'm not trying to exclude them. I'm trying to be accessible. But I'd like to challenge their ears at the same time. I don't want to be like gee what just happened? I want them to go, "That was interesting, I think."

MR: Can you expand on that a little bit? Because I've heard other people say, Herbie Hancock said, "We're in the moment when we play." I'm not sure what that means to everybody.

GG: If I hear a so-called jazz performance. If I know the bass player. I know the bass player so I go to a set and I hear a rhythm section, a horn player and a singer. And they do the first

set. And then the club empties out. But I know the bass player. So I'm going to hang on the break. So I hang around for the second set. And if they do the exact same thing on the second set as they do on the first set they're not in the moment. It's regurgitation. It's a job. It's running a drill press. You might as well get a job running a drill press. The benefits are better. But there's nothing — I don't want to say artistic because I don't like that word — there's nothing spontaneous. There's nothing that I'm moved by that makes me do something different. I mean I have seen some really high end professional people do that. And maybe they know what works. We have a show. We've worked out a show. We're going to take this show on the road and we're going to do it for nine months. Whew. I couldn't do that. I'd be bored stiff. I would be bored stiff. I'm going to go back to Thelonious Monk because he's one of my favorites. I saw a lot of concerts of Monk on YouTube. I got some live recordings of his, I've got records of his. Somebody interviewed him a very long time ago and said, "Mr. Monk, in essence you play the same music over and over again. Why is that?" And Monk said, "I'm waiting for them to play it right." Well I think he was half kidding, because he had some great bands. I mean that music was elevating when they played.

[Gap]

GG: But that's just me, I'm not saying that it's wrong. If I want to play a bossa nova then I'll play a bossa nova. And if I want to play a waltz I won't turn "Take Five" into a waltz. I mean I heard, "Let's play 'Take Five' in six." Why? Play something in six if you want to play something in six." But we want to be innovative.

MR: Yeah. Don't be too cute.

GG: Yeah. You're forcing it.

MR: Why don't you like the word "artistic"?

GG: It gets thrown around too easy. "Oh I'm an artist." Really? You paint? That's what I think. An artist is somebody who creates a sculpture or a painting or something. I mean there are some guys that are musical artists. Let me go back to I hear Charlie Parker was an artist. No he wasn't. Maybe he was a genius I don't know. Maybe he was an artist. Maybe he was. But to me he was an innovator. And I don't think he set out to be one, it happens. I don't think John Coltrane sat down in his living room one day and said — you know — I mean I think he was reaching but I don't think he said, I think tonight I'm going to do this just to sound different. I think he was reaching and he didn't know what he was reaching for, and if you keep reaching maybe you'll get to touch it. I don't know. I mean Monk played different. Maybe he set out to play different but I don't think he had a formula for what he was going to do. "I think I'm going to end a lot of my songs with that five and flat five together, bling." I think it just happened. But it happened because he was open to being different. Then again, if you're too different, "Oh that's too

different baby, we can't use you, sorry." I mean those guys weren't even recognized at first because they were too different. "You're too different man, can't you just fall in?" "Well if I fall in then I'm going to be just like everybody else."

MR: Yeah. Like Lester was going to be like Coleman Hawkins, remember?

GG: "Ivy Divy baby, I ain't playing that. I'm playing me. You know? So it's hard to be different you know. And you know I'm not saying it's hard to be different because I'm different, I don't think I am. I am not innovating. I'm following in the steps of some people that I dug. I'm not even trying to be a torch bearer or any of that other stuff. I just happen to like the music that I sing. I like that music. I don't know if — I mean you never know, you never know until it happens, but if somebody came up to me and said, "Listen baby, we're going to dress you up like Aerosmith and we want you to do music like that. We're going to get you three guitars, a couple of electric basses, some big speakers, and we'll get you a wig because we know you can't grow any more hair, and we're going to dress you up wild baby. You're going to look like Jimi Hendrix." You know I saw Jimi Hendrix live, I dug what he was doing. But that's not what I want to do. Now I don't think I could pull it off and be believable anyway, even if they said, "Listen, we're going to give you a million dollars." Well guess what. You just hit my number. I'll do it baby. Whatever you want I'll do it. I'll dress up like a girl, I'll do whatever you want to do. A million dollars? But nobody would believe it. They'd say, "He's awful." This isn't the truth. He can't sing "I Can't Get No Satisfaction" and be believable, because he's faking it, he's fronting. Maybe I should do that you know. If you know anybody that wants that and they've got like seven figures, let me know. I'll try it.

MR: Maybe there's a Guggenheim there.

GG: But you know, I mean I'm making fun, but that wouldn't work either because that's been done. You know you can't do Mick Jagger. Mick Jagger is doing Mick Jagger. You can't do Aerosmith because Aerosmith is doing it. You've got to be new and different. And when you're new and different then you risk being shut out if you're too different. Like how did Kiss make it. How did they dress up in those costumes and they made it. I mean they were huge. Somebody had to have a good idea. And then somebody had to make it happen. Listen we've got some connections and we're going to put you here, there and everywhere, and we're going to put you in print and we're going to put you on video and we're going to put you on MTV or whatever you want to call it, and we're going to make you happen. There are certain restaurants that have like over eight billion sold but is that the best place to eat? Probably not. Cause if you tell me about a really great restaurant somewhere and we go, I bet you there's no sign over the top that says over eight billion served. Cause it's hip and inside and only some people go to it, and it might even be expensive.

MR: Just to wrap up, is there anything that really aggravates you on the bandstand?

GG: Tight shoes. Not being able to hear myself is a big deal. Because as a singer we have no buttons to get that B flat out. If I can't hear me, if I can't hear the band and hear me in reference to the music that's being played, it's so hard to sing if you can't hear yourself. Bad sound is probably the worst. And then after that is time. If we're not in time then it's not happening. I'd rather hear people — I mean I don't want to hear anybody be out of tune, but I'd rather hear a little out of tune than a little out of time.

MR: Have you ever waved anybody off?

GG: Yeah. Hopefully it was funny. But yeah. "Lay out, baby." Yeah.

MR: Yeah. "Lay out, baby."

GG: But you have to do that. And the only way I could do that is by seeing — I've seen it happen. I've seen the guys who I looked up to. If it's not happening you've got to fix it right then and there. It's not about being the boss or being pushy, but you know you're in the moment. It's spontaneous. We've got to fix this now. We can't say, "Excuse me a minute, we need to talk about this." No. Lay out. It's got to take place. It's got to happen. You want to fix it right now. It's like something's going to fall and you've got to catch it. I might not have been comfortable with myself afterwards, but it happens.

MR: Well you're almost establishing a level of — I'm not going to use the word "artistic" — but I am anyway.

GG: Yeah.

MR: You're establishing a level of — this has to be up to a certain level and it's not, so let's fix it.

GG: Yeah. And we've got to fix it now cause it's going to get worse. If we just keep going down that road it's going to get worse, it's going to fall apart. So if I can fix it I'll try to. I think it's better to stop and start over then to continue for another six minutes and have it not work. Because they dig it. They don't have to be, you know, accomplished musicians to know it's not working. "Something's wrong here, Ralph." Yeah. I don't know what it is either but something's wrong. You try to fix it.

MR: Okay to wrap up I'll put you on the spot. The last interview I asked you advice for aspiring musicians and you said, "Get a little metronome, put new batteries in it, and swallow it."

GG: So you have good time.

MR: So you have good time. Do you have another gem like that that you could offer me?

GG: Listen. Listen. Listen to the best of the best. And when you're on the bandstand listen to what's going on around you. Listen. Listen to — go listen live. Listen to great recordings. Be in it. Be in it cause you dig it, not just because you know. I think I should be a country & western star but I'm not a country & western star. I used to sing country & western but

I think I'm going to sing jazz. And if that doesn't work well I'll sing pop. And if that doesn't work maybe I'll take some classical lessons and I'll be a tenor. Well then you just want to be on the bandstand. You don't have a love for a specific kind of music. Or maybe you have a broad love for music, I don't know. But to me either you have some kind of a taste or a proclivity to do something specific because you dig it. Well I mean I can't just say, "I think I'll sing country & western." Because I won't be believable. It's not where I'm coming from. So if you really come from a country & western, great. But you can't just decide to sing jazz. You can, but you better take a couple of years to sit down and listen to the best of the best. Otherwise there's no reference. You know, if you want to be a plumber you've got to work around plumbers for a while. I think, I mean, listen. And I think that you should try to listen objectively and then you should listen to yourself and try to be objective. If you really like what you do all the time then you ain't listening. You know? And even go as far as, I know the first time I was recorded, a visual recording, an audio and visual recording. And I looked at it and I was — it made me uncomfortable. So I watched it again, and again and again and again. Someone said to me, "You must really like watching yourself." "Not really. I don't like what I see. I'm going to try to fix it." But no matter what I do is fine. No it ain't. So that's why I liked watching people that I thought wow, they make this look easy because they're thinking about what they're doing. Then after a while they don't have to think about what they're doing because it comes natural. They know how to do it. Can I just say and I saw an interview of the great actor who played in the movie with Dustin Hoffman when they were drilling his teeth — "The Marathon Man." What was his name?

MR: A German.

GG: Yeah, he played the German dentist.

MR: Yes.

GG: But he's a great actor. I can't think of his name.

MR: Is it Maximillian —

GG: No but like that.

MR: Like that. Yeah.

GG: A British cat I think. I don't remember. But that scene. I remember watching the scene. I think Dustin Hoffman was on Johnny Carson or something. It was a long time ago. I wasn't in the music business. And Dustin Hoffman said that he stayed awake all night. He wouldn't let himself go to sleep so that when he came in the next morning and he was drinking coffee, he was all like, he had the jingles you know. And they're going to do this scene where he's interrogating him and they keep him up all night. And he was a mess. Dustin Hoffman was a mess. I wish I could remember this guy's name, just out of respect to him, because he's a great actor. He said to him, "Dustin, what's wrong with you?" He

said, “Well you know I stayed up all night, man, so I could really be in front of the camera.” And the cat says, “Dustin, it’s much easier to just act.” But you got to know how to act. You’ve got to know how to be able to turn the switch on and do it. And that takes a long time to get there. It takes a long time. I thought it was a great story by Dustin Hoffman, and a real nod to this great actor who I apologize for not thinking of his name. But it takes a long time to get it right. And if you get it right that’s cause you worked hard and you got lucky.

MR. Well on that note, it’s a good note.

GG: I thank you so much.

MR: I enjoyed your gig and I look forward to the next time.

GG: Thank you, me too.

MR: I’m sure it won’t be boilerplate the same.

GG: That’s because I forgot already what happened.

MR: All right Giacomo, thanks a lot.

GG: Thank you, Monk.